



▲ The WAG1 20710 or *Bidhan* was built in the Chittaranjan Locomotive Works in 1963. This was the first indigenous electric freight locomotive.

Plan of action

Every Five-Year Plan concentrated on a specific aspect of developing and strengthening the railways, wrote author MA Rao in his book *Indian Railways*. The First Five Year Plan (1951–56) looked at fortifying and reconstructing the crumbling railway system, a legacy of World War II and Partition. Emphasis was placed on the development of the indigenous capacity for the production of railway equipment. However, even though the Government adopted several successful measures to develop the domestic capacity, the limited supply was unable to keep up with the ever-increasing demand for rail transportation. The Second Five Year Plan (1956–61) sought to correct this severe mismatch between demand and supply through policies that aimed at handling increased traffic through capacity expansion and modernization. The extensive measures did have a significant impact in narrowing the demand and supply gap, yet, towards the end of 1961, there were still many pockets of paucity. The Third Five Year Plan (1961–66) and the consecutive Annual Plans of 1966–67 and 1968–69 attempted to bridge